

Handout

Lecture 4

Psychology and Health Impacts

This lecture aims to provide an overview about how psychological knowledge can be applied to explain and enhance physical health and well-being. The field of health psychology will be introduced. Examples of the associations between physical health and psychological factors (e.g., personality types, stress, and coping) will be highlighted. With these highlights, learners should be able to better understand and manage psychological factors to enhance their physical health.

Health Psychology

The role of psychology in contributing to ones' physical health and well-being is studied in the field of health psychology, which aims to examine how psychological factors are related to the promotion and maintenance of health. Health psychology also helps explain the roles of psychological factors in causing, preventing, and alleviating illness.

Health psychology advocates the biopsychosocial model which suggests that illness is caused by a complex interaction between biological (e.g., genes), psychological (e.g., personality, stress), and socio-cultural factors (e.g., cultural values, social support). Thus, the explanations of illness can be made in relation to ones' personality as well as their stress and coping strategies which help complement those from the biological and social perspectives.

Psychological Factors and Physical Health

Personality

Empirical findings have identified associations between personality types and health outcomes. One such association is between Type A Personality and the risks for cardiovascular disease. Type A personality reflects the degree to which ones are oriented toward competitiveness, impatience, stress, hostility, and cynical anger. Whereas this personality helps enhance ones' ambitions and achievements, its cynical hostility and anger components are positively associated with the risks.

The associations between hostility and anger and the risks for cardiovascular disease can be explained in many ways. Firstly, these negative emotions could lead to stress, which causes wear and tear in the cardiovascular system. Additionally, hostility and anger could cause relationship problems, bring about stress, and reduce the social support that ones

obtain. Lastly, poor health habits could result from cynicism in the hostility and reduce the degree to which ones would care for their health.

Apart from its direct association with physical health, personality can also influence our emotions and lifestyle, which in turn impact our physical health. For example, as stated earlier, Type A personality can contribute to higher levels of stress which is associated with various health problems such as compromised immune systems and gastrointestinal disorders. Obesity is another health problem which can result from one's lifestyle and personality.

Stress

Stress has been shown to have negative impacts on physical health. Before discussing the ways to regulate stress, an initial understanding of this psychological construct would help ones better manage this emotion.

Stress can occur during the circumstances that are perceived to threaten ones' well-being and tax their coping abilities. Stress is common in our daily living and can occur even from positive life changes (e.g., marriage, work promotion). Moreover, when occurring in an appropriate amount, stress could be beneficial as it can be converted into positive energy and become motivating (i.e., eustress). However, when it escalates and becomes excessive, stress could be taxing physically and psychologically.

What causes stress (i.e., stressor) depends on our appraisals (i.e., evaluation) of the situation. There are two steps of the appraisal process. First, the primary appraisal is the evaluation of whether the situation encountered is relevant and threatening to ourselves. If so, the secondary appraisal is made to evaluate whether ones' coping resources are sufficient for managing the situation. This perception of coping resources will determine the intensity of the stress experienced. If the situation is indeed relevant and threatening and we do not have sufficient coping resources, we are more likely to experience stress.

With the understanding of the two steps of stress appraisal, we could become more mindful when coming across potentially stressful situations. First, when coming across "commonly perceived as stressful" situations (e.g., examinations), we should step back and carefully examine the degree to which the situations are relevant to our overall goals. Also, the threat levels should be carefully determined as they might differ across different situations (e.g., all examinations are not necessarily equally relevant or threatening to our course of studies). Additionally, even if the relevance and threats are confirmed, we could

examine how much resources (e.g., time, social support, lessons from past experiences) we could draw to cope with the situation at hand.

Coping Strategies

Coping is essential for our management of life challenges. Coping strategies vary in terms of their effectiveness as well as their physical health impacts. One coping method that could illustrate such impact is emotional eating—food consumption engaged not to satisfy our physical needs but to fulfill our psychological ones.

Emotional eating is quite unique in its characteristics. The eating usually involves high calorie food and is normally conducted quickly and secretly. The sense of compromised control over the eating and potential subsequent negative emotions (e.g., shame and guilt) could make us feel hesitant to share about the eating. Other than these negative feelings, emotional eating could lead to concerns regarding the increased caloric intake and subsequent compensatory behaviors (e.g., excessive exercise, starvation, purging). As a result, emotional eating could sometimes escalate into eating disorders, particularly bulimia nervosa.

As its name conveys, emotional eating has a key function in emotion regulation. The eating is used either to enhance positive emotions (e.g., food is used for celebration) or to alleviate the negative ones (e.g., food is used to provide emotional comfort). Explanations for this behavior could be drawn from various psychological perspectives. Based on operant conditioning, food is rewarding such that it satisfies our hunger and promises pleasant tastes and aroma. Additionally, based on classical conditioning, food is often associated with positive emotional experiences (e.g., food accompanies the heartwarming feeling during family dining time and is quite indispensable in celebrations). With these associations, food becomes a conditioned stimulus that elicits a conditioned response of positive emotions.

The aforementioned positive emotions promised by food becomes heightened during dieting, when we are deprived of caloric intake. Then, a yearning for food becomes even more heightened. Often, a slip during dieting could escalate into emotional eating and leave us in a vicious cycle that, despite its temporary mood enhancement, food consumption leads to a subsequent concern for weight gain. This could add up to subsequent stress, which many cope subsequently with emotional eating. Hence, the vicious cycle continues.

Similar to emotional eating, some other coping strategies that promise temporary emotional reliefs could post long-term health threats. **Gaming, smoking, or drinking** are

some of the coping strategies that, if used excessively, could leave adverse health impacts. Apart from emotional enhancement, these coping strategies sometimes also serve other functions. For instance, gaming could help maintain ones' fantasy and social connection. Some people might perceive smoking and drinking as a way to maintain group membership (i.e., potentially experiencing "pluralistic ignorance" when ones feel hesitant to decline invitations to smoke or drink, assuming that others feel comfortable to do so).

Despite the various reasons that we engage in coping strategies that could have negative health impacts, a common set of strategies could be employed to reduce such engagement. These involve: 1) identifying the urge for engaging in unhelpful coping strategies (e.g., considering if the urge for eating comes from physical hunger or psychological needs), 2) if the urge is emotion-based, try to delay or resist the urge, 3) if this is irresistible, choose a predetermined healthy food choice, 4) eating slowly and mindfully, 5) equipping ourselves with alternative coping methods, and 6) addressing the causes of the negative emotions to reduce the needs for coping.

Lecture 4

Research

1. Personality as Risk and Resilience in Physical Health

- Existing research evidence illustrates the associations between different personality characteristics (e.g., Type A personality, neuroticism, conscientiousness) and their influences on physical health. Possible mechanisms underlying these associations are suggested (e.g., personality influences appraisal and coping).
- <https://www.semanticscholar.org/paper/Personality-as-Risk-and-Resilience-in-Physical-Smith/8b5e4c3338dadbe6c9768cd44e02c62a32c1a7bd>

2. Dynamics of a Stressful Encounter: Cognitive Appraisal, Coping, and Encounter Outcomes

- The Stress and Coping Theory identifies two processes, cognitive appraisal and coping, which are critical to how individuals experience stress and its outcomes.
- https://www.researchgate.net/publication/232485259_Dynamics_of_a_Stressful_Encounter_Cognitive_Appraisal_Coping_and_Encounter_Outcomes

3. Cross-national outcomes of stress appraisal

- How the appraisal of stress as eustress (positive) or distress (negative) can lead to positive or negative psychological outcomes.
- <https://www.emerald.com/insight/content/doi/10.1108/13527601211269996/full/html#idm45153354204672>

4. Emotional Eating

- Summary of research findings about emotional eating as an emotion regulation strategy, possible underlying mechanisms and causes, and clinical implications.
- https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-1-4419-6953-8_17

Application

1. 8 Hidden Health Effects of Chronic Stress

- How stress can directly and indirectly affect physical health, and some physical symptoms of stress that we might not be aware of.
- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/friendship-20/202106/8-hidden-health-effects-chronic-stress>

2. Reframe Stress

- Understanding positive reappraisal of stressful/distressing events and how it can be done
- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/between-cultures/202005/reframe-stress>

3. Stress Can Be Good for You

- Instead of trying to suppress or minimize stress, this article suggests acceptance and positive evaluation as a more adaptive way to deal with stress. Some strategies are also recommended.
- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/between-cultures/202008/stress-can-be-good-you>

4. How Your Personality Type Affects Your Health

- <https://www.verywellmind.com/how-personality-type-affects-health-4153786>